

BEETS *Beta vulgaris*

Beets are a highly underrated vegetable—being not only simple to grow, but also a delicious, versatile culinary crop; grow roots for pickling or eating fresh in salads, and harvest the bright, beautiful leaves when young to be eaten raw or cooked like spinach. Beets come in a multitude of sizes, shapes, and colors, from the standard purple globes, to tiny baby beets, in a range of colors from orange or white, to pink-and-white striped.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Beets will grow almost anywhere, but they prefer a sunny, open site and light, sandy soil, with a pH of around 6.5–7. It can sometimes be difficult to encourage beet seeds to germinate, so soak them in warm water for about an hour before planting—this will remove any traces of germination inhibitor.

Sow early, bolt-resistant seed under cover of a cloche or cold frame while there's still risk of frost, or directly into the ground between late spring and summer. Sow standard-sized beets 4 in (10 cm) apart, and smaller varieties about 2 in (5 cm) apart, at a depth of 1 in (2.5 cm), with 6 in (15 cm) between rows. Thin seedlings, if necessary.



Thin out seedlings as they develop.

CROP CARE

Protect seedlings and young plants against frosts or pests, as necessary. Once established, water in moderation; too much water will encourage leafy growth but no root, while too little will turn the root woody. Spray with a foliar, seaweed-based fertilizer once or twice during growth to boost levels of manganese and boron in the soil.